

The G-8

His brain trust is made of young professionals and first-time MPs

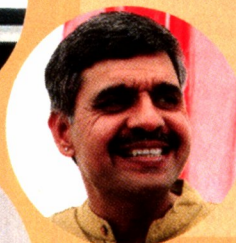
KANISHKA SINGH

A former merchant banker, he is Rahul's most trusted aide and Rajasthan Governor S.K. Singh's son. Simply referred to as K.



MANEESH TEWARI

The suave former Youth Congress president was Rahul's choice as party spokesperson. His legal credentials are a bonus.



SANDEEP DIKSHIT

Sheila Dikshit's down-to-earth son has a special rapport due to his NGO connections. Rahul promotes him on tribal and rural issues.

PANKAJ SHANKAR

Manages the media and the Gandhi website. Caught Rahul's eye with his film on Gujarat riots, *In the Name of Faith*.



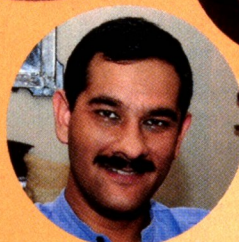
MILIND DEORA

The only one who was friends with Rahul before the two joined politics. During Rahul's campaign tours, he mobilises the young MPs for backroom support.



JITIN PRASADA

Part of the Doon brigade, he is Rahul's point man for Uttar Pradesh. He fields Prasada in Parliament to take on SP and BSP.



BHANWAR JITENDRA SINGH

AICC secretary attached to Rahul. A member of the Alwar royal family and two-term MLA. Rahul got him a Lok Sabha ticket this election.

somewhere," he says with a shrug. But he himself has the habit of pressing the wrong switches.

His vision for India, like his mother, harks back to the Nehruvian model of socialism. He talks in earnest clichés. He wants to bridge the gap between the two Indias. While he agrees with the Left that the distribution of wealth has to reach the poor, unlike the communists, he realises the need to build corporate India as well. "There is a connection between growth and distribution that the Left ignores. The Left supported us on the Employment Guarantee Scheme but where did the money

come from? It did not fall from the sky but came from 8 per cent GDP growth," he says, putting his M Phil in Development Economics to use. His night-outs at Dalit and tribal homes have been ridiculed by his political opponents and by the media, but that did not deter him from continuing his self-appointed task of discovering the other India.

Still, the one big idea that marks change is missing. If he is the change that Congress wants to be, or the change that the party wants to sell to post-Manmohan India, Rahul has to reveal his mind with more clarity. He doesn't mark an

audacious break from the past; he uses the hoary tradition of Congress's subordination to the Dynasty to his advantage. His performance as a parliamentarian or as a Youth Congress leader is pretty dismal; at no point he convinced the country that he was the change India had been waiting for. A few contradictory statements about potential allies do not mark the repudiation of politics-as-usual. He is still the Dynasty's indulged child enjoying his freedom—and the knowledge that he is the One. Unlike his voters, he doesn't have to worry about an Employment Guarantee Act. His employment was guaranteed the moment he was born. If a Gandhi is entitled to such a privilege, we are entitled to know whether he is worthy of it.

with bureau inputs

"Thousands of villages are waiting for drinking water and Rahul talks of poverty sitting in air-conditioned rooms." NARENDRA MODI, Gujarat Chief Minister